WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital with Emerging & Frontier Markets

RWANDA

Africa

Information current as of October 2026

Dialogue | Trust | Partnership

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WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Kigali	Capital and commercial centre; regional hub for conferences, financial services and regional headquarters, home to the Kigali International Financial Centre	Financial services, ICT, MICE tourism, real estate
Kigali Special Economic Zone	Rwanda's flagship industrial zone, anchoring a manufacturing and agro-processing base that attracted $738.5 million of registered investment in 2025	Light manufacturing, agro-processing, construction materials
Bugesera (south of Kigali)	Site of the $2 billion Bugesera International Airport, developed with Qatar Airways (60% stake), with its first phase due to open in 2028	Aviation, logistics, manufacturing, real estate
Musanze / Volcanoes National Park (north)	Centre of Rwanda's premium gorilla-tourism model and a cornerstone of its high-value, low-volume tourism strategy	High-value tourism, hospitality, conservation
Mining districts (Western, Northern and Southern provinces)	Tin, tantalum and gold production and processing, with lithium exploration under way and a national mineral-export target of over $2.17 billion by 2029	Mining, mineral processing, exploration services
Rubavu / Rusizi (Lake Kivu)	Western border cities on Lake Kivu and the main gateways for cross-border trade with eastern DRC	Cross-border trade, logistics, energy, tourism
Provincial industrial parks	A growing network of industrial parks designed to decentralise manufacturing beyond Kigali	Agro-processing, manufacturing, logistics

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Rwanda Development Board (RDB), the national investment agency, offering one-stop business registration, investment certificates, aftercare and sector guidance
- Law No. 006/2021 on Investment Promotion and Facilitation, providing incentives for priority sectors, international headquarters and qualifying export-oriented investors
- Kigali International Financial Centre (KIFC), promoted by Rwanda Finance Limited, offering a dedicated regime for funds, holding companies and Africa-focused capital
- Kigali Special Economic Zone and the expanding network of provincial industrial parks, with serviced land for manufacturing and export projects

- National Bank of Rwanda regulation of the Rwandan franc, foreign-exchange dealings and the banking system, through which investment flows and repatriation are channelled
- Mining licences and exploration rights through the Rwanda Mines, Petroleum and Gas Board, covering tin, tantalum, gold and emerging lithium exploration
- Public-private partnerships for infrastructure, energy and aviation projects, coordinated by RDB and the Ministry of Finance and Economic Planning

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Rwanda in October 2026 is one of Africa's fastest-growing economies. GDP expanded 9.4% in 2025, led by industry and services, and growth reached 9.7% in the first half of 2026, with industry up 18% and mining up 26% in the second quarter; the IMF projects 7.8% for 2026 as a whole. Registered investment reached $2.62 billion across 799 projects in 2025, led by real estate, manufacturing and mining, and mineral exports rose to $1.75 billion in 2024. The IMF approved a new Extended Credit Facility arrangement in June 2026 and reached staff-level agreement on its first review in October 2026, noting that all end-June performance criteria were met. Flagship projects such as the $2 billion Bugesera International Airport and the Kigali International Financial Centre underpin the longer-term growth story.

Rwanda's main near-term challenge is managing inflation and external financing alongside very strong growth. Inflation rose to 17.2% in September 2026, driven mainly by fresh food and energy prices, including spillovers from higher global oil and fertiliser costs, while public debt stood at 74.8% of GDP in FY2024/25, below the 80.5% previously projected, with concessional loans making up 88.2% of external borrowing. The authorities have responded decisively: the National Bank of Rwanda has raised its policy rate by a cumulative 175 basis points since November 2025, to 8.75% in August 2026, and expects inflation to return to target in the second half of 2027. Reserves cover about four months of imports and the IMF rates debt-distress risk as moderate, with its programme anchoring fiscal consolidation. For investors, this policy discipline supports stability, and import substitution in food processing, construction materials and light manufacturing offers clear opportunity.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
US sanctions on the Rwanda Defence Force	In March 2026 the US Treasury (OFAC) designated the Rwanda Defence Force and four senior officers over support for M23 in eastern DRC, and in June 2026 sanctioned Kigali's Gasabo Gold Refinery and linked mining companies; the wider Government of Rwanda is not designated	Commerce with Rwanda remains lawful, but investors should use sanctions counsel to screen counterparties, including any entity 50% or more owned by designated parties, and avoid defence-linked partners
Eastern DRC conflict and regional relations	Rwanda and the DRC signed the US-brokered Washington Accords in December 2025, including a Regional Economic Integration Framework, although implementation is at an early stage	The integration framework targets mining value chains, energy, infrastructure and tourism; monitor progress and build regional scenarios into planning
Mineral supply-chain due diligence	Mineral trade in the Great Lakes region faces close scrutiny over origin and traceability, as reflected in the June 2026 US sanctions on a gold refinery and three mining companies	Apply OECD-aligned due diligence and independent traceability; partner with established, audited producers in Rwanda's own mining districts
Elevated inflation and rising interest rates	Inflation reached 17.2% in September 2026 and the policy rate has risen to 8.75%, raising local borrowing costs	Assertive monetary tightening and the IMF programme support a return to target in 2027; consider offshore or DFI financing and price local contracts with indexation
Public debt and financing needs	Public debt was 74.8% of GDP in FY2024/25, reflecting heavy public investment in infrastructure, and Fitch expects it to peak at around 79% in 2027	Debt is largely concessional and the IMF arrangement supports consolidation; growing reliance on PPPs creates openings for private capital in infrastructure
Small, landlocked market	A small domestic market and long overland routes to the ports of Mombasa	Use Rwanda as a well-governed base for EAC, COMESA and AfCFTA markets; the

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
	and Dar es Salaam raise logistics costs	new Bugesera airport will strengthen air-cargo and hub capacity

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Rwanda's risk profile combines exceptional growth, a strong reputation for effective governance and ease of doing business, and an active reform agenda with two areas requiring careful management. On the macroeconomic side, inflation and public debt are elevated, but the central bank's decisive tightening, reserves of about four months of imports, a largely concessional debt profile and the IMF Extended Credit Facility provide a credible anchor. On the legal and geopolitical side, the 2026 US sanctions on the Rwanda Defence Force, four senior officers, the Gasabo Gold Refinery and linked mining companies are a material compliance consideration: US persons cannot deal with designated parties or entities 50% or more owned by them, and international investors should commission sanctions and ownership screening and rigorous mineral-traceability checks. These measures are targeted rather than economy-wide, and the Washington Accords signed in December 2025 provide a framework for de-escalation and regional economic integration. Investors who build strong compliance into their entry can benefit from one of Africa's most efficient business environments and from any further normalisation of regional relations.

MARKET ACCESS

Rwanda is a member of the East African Community (EAC), providing access to a regional market of several hundred million people, as well as COMESA and the African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA), and has been a WTO member since 1996. As a Commonwealth member with English and French in official use, it bridges anglophone and francophone Africa. Exports centre on minerals, which earned $1.75 billion in 2024, alongside coffee, tea and services, with merchandise exports up 51% in the second quarter of 2026, with tourism and conference business making Kigali one of Africa's leading MICE destinations. Goods move by road along the Northern Corridor to Mombasa and the Central Corridor to Dar es Salaam, while the Bugesera International Airport, due to open in 2028, and RwandAir's network are positioning Kigali as an air-logistics hub. The Washington Accords' Regional Economic Integration Framework could, as implementation proceeds, deepen trade and investment links with the DRC and the wider Great Lakes region.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Office of the President (Paul Kagame)	Sets national development strategy, including the NST-2 transformation programme and regional diplomacy around the Washington Accords	Primary reference point for strategic direction and flagship-project priorities
Rwanda Development Board (RDB)	National investment, export and tourism agency running one-stop registration and investor aftercare	Standard first point of contact for market entry, incentives and licensing
National Bank of Rwanda	Monetary authority and financial regulator, leading the 2026 response to inflation	Relevant for currency, banking, capital-flow and licensing matters
Ministry of Finance and Economic Planning (MINECOFIN)	Manages the budget, public debt, the IMF programme and the PPP framework	Key counterpart for infrastructure, PPP and public-financing engagement
Rwanda Finance Limited / Kigali International Financial Centre	Promotes Kigali as a domicile for funds, holding companies and Africa-focused capital	Preferred venue for structuring regional investment vehicles
Rwanda Mines, Petroleum and Gas Board	Regulates and licenses mining and leads the drive toward a mineral-export target of over $2.17 billion by 2029	Essential partner for mining, exploration and mineral-processing investment
Ministry of Foreign Affairs and International Cooperation	Leads relations with the US, DRC, EU and regional partners, including Washington Accords implementation	Relevant for understanding regional dynamics and the integration framework

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The Private Sector Federation (PSF) is the main umbrella for domestic business and runs regular bilateral business forums, while the Rwanda Development Board hosts investor outreach and sector-specific promotion. The UK–Rwanda Business Forum and Commonwealth business networks are useful channels for British and Commonwealth investors. Kigali's role as a leading African conference venue, through events at the Kigali Convention Centre, makes it an effective place to meet regional decision-makers. The IMF, through its Extended Credit Facility, and development partners such as the World Bank and African Development Bank support infrastructure, energy and private-sector programmes, and the Kigali International Financial Centre increasingly acts as a networking hub for Africa-focused funds.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Rwanda best suits investors who value governance quality, speed of execution and a regional platform: financial-services firms and fund managers using the Kigali International Financial Centre; manufacturing, agro-processing and construction-materials investors targeting import substitution through the special economic zone and industrial parks; tourism, hospitality and MICE operators; ICT and fintech businesses; and infrastructure investors in aviation, energy and logistics through PPPs. Mining investors can benefit from strong policy support for minerals and lithium exploration, provided they apply rigorous supply-chain due diligence. All investors, and particularly those with US nexus, should incorporate sanctions screening into counterparty selection.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage the Rwanda Development Board on incentives and registration
Open dialogue with RDB to confirm sector incentives under the 2021 investment law and use its one-stop registration and aftercare services.

STEP 2: Commission sanctions and ownership screening
Engage sanctions counsel to screen partners against US designations, including entities owned by the Rwanda Defence Force, and apply OECD-aligned due diligence to any mineral supply chain.

STEP 3: Evaluate the Kigali International Financial Centre for regional structuring
Consider KIFC vehicles for holding, fund and treasury structures serving EAC, COMESA and AfCFTA markets.

STEP 4: Build inflation and currency scenarios into planning
Factor 2026 inflation and interest-rate levels into financing and pricing, using hedging, indexation or DFI and offshore funding.

STEP 5: Track flagship projects and regional integration
Follow the Bugesera airport, industrial-zone expansion and Washington Accords economic framework for emerging supply, logistics and partnership opportunities.